Land that started in October 2015. During the first month alone there were 14 attacks (mostly stabbings) in Hebron, which accounted for more than a quarter of the nationwide total.

The events of 24 March followed a familiar pattern. Two Palestinians, Ramzi al-Kasrawi and Abdel Fattah al-Sharif, approached a group of Israeli soldiers and stabbed one of them. They were quickly shot, and the Israeli army issued the kind of statement that it had put out almost daily since the winter: “Forces responded to the attack and shot the assailants, which resulted in their deaths.”

But then B’Tselem, a prominent Israeli human rights group, released a video shot by a Palestinian employee who lived nearby. The initial shooting only resulted in the death of one attacker, Kasrawi. The three-minute clip, posted on YouTube, showed the wounded Sharif lying supine on the street, surrounded by a group of soldiers. A voice, probably one of the soldiers, warned the others that “the terrorist is still alive, the dog.” The soldiers conferred amongst themselves—then one of them shot Sharif in the head. The camera captured his blood trickling down the pavement while an ambulance slowly maneuvered into place to collect his body. The routine shooting was actually an execution.

A spokesman for the army quickly called it “very serious and atypical.” Indeed, while there had been several other questionable shootings over the past few months, none had been so brazen, nor had they been caught on tape. The soldier responsible, a 19-year-old army medic named Elor Azaria, would soon be charged with manslaughter in military court.

In previous decades, this might have been uncontroversial. One of the closest parallels—a 1984 incident in which officers killed two Palestinian bus hijackers after they were already in handcuffs—ultimately led to prosecutions. (It also led to the resignation of a director of Israel’s internal security agency, the Shin Bet, who tried to cover up the affair). But in 2016, the Azaria case polarized the nation. Members of the right-wing ruling coalition lined up to praise him. Avigdor Lieberman, who would soon be named defense minister, called him a hero. Benjamin Netanyahu, the prime minister, called the soldier’s father to offer condolences, a move that stunned what little remained of Israel’s liberal civil society. An overwhelming majority of the Israeli public said Azaria did not deserve to face criminal charges, and a petition to grant him a medal for heroism quickly garnered more than 63,000 signatures.